

THE APOSTOLIC *KERYGMA* AND THE APOSTLES' CREED: A STUDY IN COMPATIBILITY

Andrew Messmer

Introduction

Over the last several decades various Christian traditions have been engaged in ecumenical dialogue with one another in an attempt to clarify where their respective traditions agree and differ. A problematic issue faced in this dialogue is the relationship between Scripture and Tradition, especially with regard to the role of early creeds. Whereas many Protestants typically claim Scripture as their only source of authority, other Protestants, Orthodox, and Catholics understand early creeds to be authoritative as well (although in varying degrees). The first group could be labeled “*sola Scriptura*-ists” (hereafter SS) and the second could be labeled “Scripture and Creeds-ists” (hereafter SC).

In more recent decades, scholars such as D. H. Williams, Thomas Oden, and Robert Webber have attempted to introduce Protestants (many of whom fall into the SS camp) to various aspects of Tradition, including the early creeds, and to demonstrate that Scripture and Tradition are not at odds with one another. The purpose of this article is to advance this line of argumentation in one significant way, namely, to demonstrate that the apostolic *kerygma* and the Apostles' Creed overlap to such a significant extent that they can be regarded as virtually identical. This article outlines the main components of the apostolic *kerygma* as it was set forth in its classical form by C. H. Dodd and further developed by subsequent scholarship, and then compares it with the Apostles' Creed. It closes with some brief suggestions for further dialogue between the two camps.

The Apostolic Kerygma

In 1936 C. H. Dodd published his famous and influential book, *The Apostolic Preaching and Its Developments*.¹ Analyzing what he termed “*kerygmatic*” sections of Paul’s letters and of the book of Acts, Dodd noted that several themes repeatedly appeared throughout these texts, and then reconstructed their respective *kerygmata*. He based his study of the Pauline *kerygma* on Romans 1:1–4; 8:31–34; 10:8–9; 14:9–10; 1 Corinthians 15:1–11; Galatians 3:1; and 1 Thessalonians 1:9–10, and reconstructed it as follows²:

1. The prophecies are fulfilled, and the new Age is inaugurated by the coming of Christ.
2. He was born of the seed of David.
3. He died according to the Scriptures, to deliver us out of the present evil age.
4. He was buried.
5. He rose on the third day according to the Scriptures.
6. He is exalted at the right hand of God, as Son of God and Lord of quick and dead.
7. He will come again as Judge and Saviour of men.

He based his study of the Jerusalem *kerygma* on Acts 2; 3; 4; and 10, and reconstructed it as follows³:

1. The age of fulfilment has dawned.
2. This has taken place through the ministry, death, and resurrection of Jesus, of which a brief account is given, with proof from the Scriptures that all took place through “the determinate counsel and foreknowledge of God”: (a) His Davidic descent; (b) His ministry; (c) His death; (d) His resurrection.
3. By virtue of the resurrection, Jesus has been exalted at the right hand of God, as Messianic head of the new Israel.

1 *The Apostolic Preaching and Its Developments: Three Lectures* (London: Hodder & Stoughton Limited, 1936).

2 *Apostolic Preaching*, 28.

3 *Apostolic Preaching*, 38–43.

4. The Holy Spirit in the Church is the sign of Christ's present power and glory.
5. The Messianic Age will shortly reach its consummation in the return of Christ.
6. The *kerygma* always closes with an appeal for repentance, the offer of forgiveness and of the Holy Spirit, and the promise of "salvation," that is, of "the life of the Age to Come," to those who enter the elect community.

As can be seen (and as Dodd himself argued⁴), there is much overlap between these two *kerygmata*, the fact of which ought not to be surprising since Paul himself claimed that he and the other Apostles preached the same *kerygmatic* message (cf. Gal 2:7–9; 1 Cor 15:11). Therefore, it seems justifiable to combine Dodd's Pauline and Jerusalem *kerygmata* into a unified apostolic *kerygma*, which would take the following shape:⁵

1. The prophecies are fulfilled and the age of fulfilment has dawned.
 2. This has taken place through the ministry, death, and resurrection of Jesus, of which a brief account is given: (a) His Davidic descent; (b) His ministry; (c) His death for our sins; (d) His resurrection.
 3. By virtue of the resurrection, Jesus has been exalted at the right hand of God as Lord, Christ, and Son of God.
 4. The Holy Spirit in the Church is the sign of Christ's present power and glory.
4. Dodd noted six apparent discrepancies between the two *kerygmata*. He concluded that five of the six apparent discrepancies could readily be harmonized once issues like literary context and semantic overlap of Christological titles were taken into account (*Apostolic Preaching*, 47–53). Of the sixth issue, namely, that Paul's *kerygma* lacked explicit references to the ministry of Jesus, His miracles, and His teaching, Dodd concluded that even this may be harmonized with the Jerusalem *kerygma* if Paul's sermon in Acts 13 were taken as representative of Paul's general form of preaching (*Apostolic Preaching*, 53–63). Thus it can be concluded that Dodd himself saw no real discrepancies between the Pauline and Jerusalem *kerygmata*. Additionally, it should be remembered that Dodd entitled his work *The Apostolic Preaching* (sg) and not *The Apostolic Preachings* (pl).
5. This is my reconstruction of the two *kerygmata*, as Dodd himself did not combine them in his work. Other reconstructions may be possible, but it is doubtful that they will differ substantially from the one presented above.

5. The Messianic Age will shortly reach its consummation in the return of Christ as Judge and Savior of mankind.
6. A call for repentance, the offer of forgiveness and of the Holy Spirit, and the promise of "salvation," that is, of "the life of the Age to Come."

Dodd's study proved to be very influential in New Testament studies, especially in the English- and German-speaking worlds. While some have been critical of Dodd's work (especially in the German-speaking world), the majority of scholars who have published on the apostolic *kerygma* since Dodd's time have agreed with his basic propositions. However, a serious deficiency in Dodd's initial work was its lack of comprehensiveness—his study only included eleven texts from four of Paul's letters and the book of Acts.⁶ Addressing this deficiency and aiming at exhaustiveness, David Selby identified and analyzed sixty-five *kerygmatic* passages from the New Testament and concluded that seven themes repeatedly occurred throughout these passages.⁷ He summarized their contents as follows:

1. *Background*: Scriptures fulfilled, appeal to natural reason, early Hebrew history, Davidic descent, John the Baptist.
2. *Messianic character*: Messiahship, King, Lordship, Just One, Servant, Holy or Righteous One, Author of Life, Son of God, Son of Man, Savior, likeness of God.

6 One scholar who noted this deficiency was James McDonald, *Kerygma and Didache: The Articulation and Structure of the Earliest Christian Message* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1980), 3.

7 *The Pre-Literary Development of the Kerygma* (unpublished Ph.D. diss. Boston University Graduate School, 1954; available online: www.open.bu.edu; accessed: 05 Apr, 2018). Selby notes Dodd's deficiency and states his aim of exhaustiveness on pp. 5–6. He divided the sixty-five passages into fifteen "direct accounts" and fifty "indirect references." The fifteen "direct accounts" are: Act 2:4–40; 3:12–26; 4:8–12; 5:20–42; 7:2–60; 10:34–43; 13:16–41, 46; 14:15–17; 16:31; 17:22–31; 22:1–21; 24:10–21; 26:2–27; Rom 1:1–6; 1 Cor 15:1–11. The fifty "indirect references" are: Act 4:1–2, 24–30, 33–35; 5:42; 6:12–14; 8:5, 12, 31–37; 9:19–22; 11:20; 14:21–23; 15:7–11, 13–21; 17:2–3, 7; 18:5, 28; 19:4, 8, 26; 20:18–35; 23:6; 24:24–25; 25:19; 28:17–28; Rom 1:16; 2:16; 10:8–9, 17; 15:19; 16:25–26; 1 Cor 1:17–18, 23–24; 2:2–5; 2 Cor 1:18–19; 4:4–14; 5:11–21; Gal 2:14–21; 3:1, 8–12; Eph 3:8–12; 6:19; Phi 1:18; Col 1:4–5, 21–23; 2:6–15; 1 Thess 1:5, 9–10; 2:13–15; 1 Tim 3:16; 2 Tim 1:8, 12; 2:2–13; Tit 1:1–3; 1 Pet 1:10–12.

3. *Life History*: good life, crucified, buried, resurrected, exalted.
4. *Effect on Believers*: followed by the Holy Spirit, power of the Name, forgiveness of sins.
5. *Eschatological Role*: salvation, eternal life, *parousia*, Jesus as Judge, kingdom of God, mystery, coming disaster.
6. *The Appeal*: call to repentance, baptism, call to faith.
7. *Cosmic (or Universal) Significance*: universality of *kerygma*, command to preach.

As can be seen, Selby developed Dodd's initial findings in two important ways. First, Selby expanded the presence of Dodd's *kerygma* in the New Testament by demonstrating that it is found in numerous passages throughout the New Testament, including several parts of Acts and the Pauline corpus, as well as 1 Peter. Also expanding the presence of Dodd's *kerygma* was F. F. Bruce, who studied the *kerygma* of the book of Hebrews and concluded that the opening verses of the book "sum up a good part of the kerygma" and concluded that "[a]ll the main features of [Dodd's] kerygma, then, are reproduced in this letter, but the exaltation of Christ to the right hand of God is elaborated here as nowhere else in the New Testament."⁸ Thus it can be concluded that large and significant portions of the New Testament bear witness to the same basic *kerygmatic* message.

Second, whereas Dodd's first component ("the prophecies are fulfilled and the age of fulfilment has dawned") contained information that would have been relevant only for a Jewish audience, Selby's findings lead him to add information that would have been relevant for a pagan audience ("appeal to natural reason"). This same addition was argued for by Harry Poe, who argued that Paul, when preaching to pagan audiences in Acts 14 and 17, began his *kerygma* by appealing to the "Creator God."⁹ Thus it can be concluded that the opening component of the *kerygmatic* message

8 "The Kerygma of Hebrews," *Interpretation* 23 no 1 (1969): 4, 7. The importance of the exaltation theme is noted below.

9 *The Gospel and Its Meaning: A Theology for Evangelism and Church Growth* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan Publishing House, 1996), 10, 45–46.

also should include information that would be relevant for a pagan audience.

In summary, and taking into account all of the relevant findings discussed thus far, the following outline can function as a summary of the apostolic *kerygma* as it appears in the New Testament:¹⁰

1. Discussion of the OT prophecies or of the Creator God in general.
2. An explanation the ministry, death, and resurrection of Jesus, of which a brief account is given: (a) His life; (b) His death; (c) His resurrection.
3. By virtue of the resurrection, Jesus has been exalted at the right hand of God as Lord, Christ, and Son of God.
4. The Holy Spirit in the Church is the sign of Christ's present power and glory.
5. Jesus is coming again as Judge and Savior of mankind.
6. An appeal for repentance, the offer of forgiveness and of the Holy Spirit, and the promise of salvation.¹¹

The Apostolic Kerygma and the Apostles' Creed

The discussion above has argued that the New Testament itself bears witness to a common apostolic *kerygma* that repeatedly evokes the same general themes that can be outlined under six main headings. In other words, any SS would be hard pressed to deny the validity that the New Testament testifies to a basic framework for setting forth the Christian faith to non-Christian audiences. What is so important about this framework for current ecumenical discussion is that it is virtually identical to the Apostles' Creed. The following is a side-by-side comparison of the apostolic *kerygma* and the Apostles' Creed (the order of the apostolic *kerygma* has been

- 10 Again, it should be noted that this is my own reconstruction of the various *kerygmata* presented thus far, and that it generally follows Dodd's reconstruction, with other authors' insights being worked into his framework. Other reconstructions may be possible, but it is doubtful that they will substantially differ than the one presented above.
- 11 The "Cosmic (or Universal) Significance" component of the *kerygma* has not been included since it is merely a call to preach said *kerygma* to all mankind.

modified in one place to adhere to that of the Apostles' Creed; the numbering indicates where said modification occurs):

Apostolic <i>kerygma</i>	Apostles' Creed¹²
1. Discussion of the OT prophecies or of the Creator God in general.	I believe in God, the Father almighty, creator of heaven and earth.
2. An explanation the ministry, death, and resurrection of Jesus, of which a brief account is given: (a) His life; (b) His death; (c) His resurrection.	I believe in Jesus Christ, his only Son, our Lord. He was conceived by the power of the Holy Spirit and born of the Virgin Mary. He suffered under Pontius Pilate, was crucified, died, and was buried. He descended into hell. On the third day he rose again.
3. By virtue of the resurrection, Jesus has been exalted at the right hand of God as Lord, Christ, and Son of God.	He ascended into heaven and is seated at the right hand of the Father.
4. Jesus is coming again as Judge and Savior of mankind.	He will come again to judge the living and the dead.
5. The Holy Spirit in the Church is the sign of Christ's present power and glory.	I believe in the Holy Spirit, the holy catholic Church, the communion of saints,
6. An appeal for repentance, the offer of forgiveness and of the Holy Spirit, and the promise of salvation.	the forgiveness of sins, the resurrection of the body, and the life everlasting. Amen.

As can be seen, there is such a high degree of convergence between these two texts—both in content as well as in order—that it can be said that there is no substantial difference between them.¹³ In other words, an appeal to the apostolic *kerygma* is an appeal to

12 English translation from *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (New York: Doubleday, 1997), 56–57.

13 The only clear difference is the apostolic *kerygma*'s "appeal for repentance" (which would not make sense in a creed). The only debatable difference would be the Apostles' Creed's "He descended into hell" (which arguably could be included in the apostolic *kerygma*'s "His death").

the Apostles' Creed, and vice versa.¹⁴ It is here, at the intersection between the apostolic *kerygma* and the Apostles' Creed, that SS and SC find common ground, and do so in a way that they can remain faithful to their respective positions. Both groups can arrive at the same destination (apostolic *kerygma*/Apostles' Creed), even if their way of getting there may be different (*sola Scriptura* vs. Scripture and creeds). Although the implications for ecumenical dialogue are somewhat mitigated by the fact that Orthodox have adopted the Nicene–Constantinopolitan Creed as opposed to the Apostles' Creed due to the former's expanded articles on the full deity of the Son and Spirit, nevertheless they do unite SS and Orthodox camps considerably, and it can be argued that the adoption of the Apostles' Creed is an initial step in the process.¹⁵

Suggestions for Further Dialogue

On the one hand, SS have much to gain in adopting the Apostles' Creed as authoritative (even secondarily so) since it provides them with a basic hermeneutical framework through which the Scriptures ought to be interpreted. It has been demonstrated above that this was how the Apostles themselves interpreted the Scriptures and how they presented their basic message to the world, and surely SS aspire to present the same basic message to non-Christians today. It should be remembered once again that in adopting the Apostles' Creed as authoritative SS are not sacrificing their *sola Scriptura* position, but rather recognizing that the Creed accurately summarizes the apostolic *kerygma* that is found throughout numerous portions of the New Testament.

On the other hand, SC benefit from an example of how to dialogue with SS regarding the role of the early creeds for the Church. The Apostles' Creed is so clearly rooted in the apostolic

14 It is in this sense that the Apostles' Creed is aptly named, since it truly summarizes the apostolic *kerygma*.

15 It is here that the contribution of the *kerygma* of the opening verses of Hebrews may prove helpful, since they are nodding in the direction of Nicea with respect to the Son's deity.

kerygma that the SS cannot help but see the overlap. SC should strive to demonstrate to SS where and how other early creeds may be equally clearly rooted in Scripture. In fact, SC may consider taking a *sola Scriptura* approach in dialoguing with SC, and as previous ecumenical dialogue has shown, it appears to be the best way to advance the conversation. Such a gesture would honor the admirable commitment that SS have to the ultimate authority of Scripture as well as make it easier for them to accept SC claims.